SAVE THE THIEF

From prototype to a successful mobile game

Full production roadmap: status, workflow, phases,
art & models, levels, UI, monetization, analytics,
store launch, marketing and live operations.

Godot 4.7 | Android first | 2.5D physics puzzle | Version 1.0 of this plan | 21 October 2026

Internal planning document

1. Summary

Save the Thief is a 2.5D physics puzzle: the player taps groups of coloured blocks so rocks, a boulder or lava drain into a safe pit instead of crushing a cartoon thief, then opens the exit. The core game already works on a real Android phone at 60 FPS with 15 verified levels, its own synthesised sound set and vibration. What remains is everything that turns a good prototype into a **product**: menus and polish, final art, many more levels, monetization, analytics, store launch and marketing.

Area	Where we are	What success needs
Gameplay	Core loop done: blocks, rocks, boulder, lava, planks, cloth	More mechanics to keep 100+ levels fresh
Levels	15 levels, each auto-tested (win path + fail path)	60 at launch, +10-20 every 2 weeks after
Visuals	Procedural wood/stone, placeholder thief	Final textures, rigged thief model, icon, UI art
Audio	Own branded synth sound + music, vibration	Final mix pass; optional pro composer later
UI	Basic HUD and win/lose popup	Menu, level map, settings, shop, hints, tutorial
Money	AdsManager stub only	Rewarded + interstitial ads, Remove Ads IAP, coins
Data	None	Firebase Analytics, Crashlytics, Remote Config
Store	Signed test APK runs on Galaxy S22 Ultra	Play Console, 12-tester closed test, AAB, listing

Strategy in one line: launch on Google Play first with a polished 60-level game and ad-based monetization, prove retention in a small soft launch, then scale with short "fail" video ads and regular level updates. iOS comes after Android numbers are good.

2. Current status (what is already built)

DONE	Godot 4.7 project, Jolt physics, portrait 1080x1920, Forward+ on PC / Mobile renderer on Android.
DONE	2.5D look: orthographic tilted camera, bevelled carved-wood walls, glossy rounded blocks, soft shadows, lanterns, dust, glow.
DONE	Block grid: tap groups of 2+, flood fill, pop particles, gravity falls, wobble on single blocks.
DONE	Hazards: rocks (faceted stones), boulder (impact shake), lava (glowing shader + moving light).
DONE	Planks on hinges (seesaw / trapdoor) and swipe-to-tear cloth covers.
DONE	Thief: placeholder model with idle/scared/cheer/run/dead; auto-uses thief.glb + animations when added.
DONE	15 levels in JSON; automated tests prove each one is winnable and that a wrong move kills the thief.
DONE	Own sound identity (synthesised marimba/pizzicato set + music loop), haptics, screen shake.
DONE	Android export, signed APK, installs over adb; 60 FPS on Galaxy S22 Ultra after mobile tuning.
DONE	Fixed: Android audio crash (music loop over-read) and mobile performance (37-44 FPS to 60 FPS).

Open issues to close first

NEXT	Phone currently has a **test build that starts at level 14**. Reinstall the normal build.
NEXT	Level 14 test: after the final tap the level restarted instead of showing the win popup. A re-test showed one tap counts once, so reproduce it slowly and fix it before more levels are built on the same flow.
NEXT	Lantern flame and light look dark on the phone (Mobile renderer). Replace with an emissive mesh that works on mobile.
TODO	Test on a low-end phone (2-3 GB RAM, e.g. Galaxy A-series / Redmi). The S22 Ultra is a high-end device.

3. How we work (the workflow)

Every change follows the same loop. This is what keeps quality high while moving fast.

Step	What happens	Tool
1. Build	Write code / levels in GDScript and JSON. Levels are generated and validated by a script.	Godot editor, Python level generator
2. Auto-test	Headless playthrough of every level: the intended solution must WIN and a wrong move must LOSE. Warnings are treated as errors.	Godot console + test scripts
3. Look	Real screenshots on PC to judge visuals.	Godot windowed capture
4. Phone	Export APK, install over USB, read FPS and crash logs from the phone.	adb, logcat
5. Play	You play and report anything that feels wrong; we fix and repeat.	Your phone
6. Release	Version bump, signed AAB, upload to the Play Console test track.	Play Console

Version control

- Put the project in **Git** now (GitHub or GitLab, private repo). Commit after every working step; tag each store release (v0.5, v1.0...).
- Never commit the release keystore or its passwords. Back the keystore up in two safe places: losing it means you can never update the app.

4. Roadmap by phase

Times assume one developer working with AI help, part to full time. Phases 2 and 3 can run in parallel with phase 1.

PHASE 1 Core polish & UI (work-order step 5) — Weeks 1-2

Goal: A complete, smooth game loop a stranger can play without help.

NEXT	Main menu: Play, Levels, Settings, Shop (later). Animated background (night sky + wooden sign).
NEXT	Level map: wooden boards with stars and locks, scrolls to the newest level.
NEXT	HUD: level name, tap counter, restart, pause, hint button with a counter.
NEXT	Hint: highlights the next correct group with the glowing outline (solution data already in each level).
NEXT	Win popup: stars fly in one by one with sound; Next / Replay. Lose popup: Retry / Watch ad to continue.
NEXT	Settings: music, sound, vibration, language, privacy, restore purchases.
NEXT	First-time tutorial: animated hand on level 1 ("tap the red blocks"), swipe hint on the first cloth level.
TODO	Loading/splash screen with logo; smooth scene transitions (fade); safe-area support for notches.
TODO	Accessibility: colour-blind mode (symbols on blocks), bigger tap tolerance option.

PHASE 2 Art, models & branding — Weeks 2-4

Goal: Look as good as the top games in the genre in store screenshots.

Asset	How	Notes
14 textures (wood, stone, lava, fabric, blocks, UI, background, icon)	ChatGPT image prompts (ASSET_PROMPTS.md, step 7)	Seamless 1024x1024; the game loads them automatically by file name
Thief 3D model	Mixamo character or commissioned (Fiverr/ArtStation), rigged	Animations: idle, scared, run, fall, cheer; drop in as assets/models/thief.glb

Asset	How	Notes
Extra characters / skins	Same rig, new textures (police hat, ninja, pirate...)	Sold in the shop later (cosmetics)
App icon	Thief face with mask, bold outline, one bright colour	Test 3 icons in Play Console store listing experiments
UI kit	Wood buttons/panels as 9-slice PNGs + one rounded display font	Use an OFL-licensed font (e.g. Fredoka, Lilita One)
Feature graphic 1024x500 + 8 screenshots	Captured in-game, framed with captions	Screenshots sell the app more than anything else
Store video (15-30 s)	Screen recording of a dramatic fail and a clever win	Same clips become ads later

PHASE 3 Levels & new mechanics

Weeks 2-6, then ongoing

Goal: Enough fresh content that players stay for weeks.

Content targets

Milestone	Levels	Why
Closed test	30	Testers need ~1 hour of play to give real feedback
Launch	60	Players finish 20-40 levels in week 1; they must not run out
+2 months	120+	Retention for players who love the game
Live	+10-20 every 2 weeks	Update cadence is a ranking and retention signal

Mechanics to add (one new idea every ~10 levels keeps it fresh)

- **Water** that puts out lava (water + lava = stone): combine hazards in one level.
- **Bombs** that clear an area; **steel blocks** that can't be tapped; **ice blocks** that need two taps.
- **Gold coins** and loot bags the thief can collect for bonus stars (and coins for the shop).
- **Guard / dog** character to protect from the hazard too (two characters, double the drama).
- **Conveyor belts, portals, magnets, gas clouds, falling chandeliers** for later chapters.
- Chapters with themes: Museum, Bank vault, Pyramid, Volcano, Pirate ship, Snow castle.

Tools that make 100+ levels possible

- **In-game level editor** (debug only): paint cells, place hazards, press Test, save JSON.
- Keep the automated **solvability test** for every level: win path + fail path must pass before release.
- Difficulty curve: easy-easy-medium-hard-breather pattern; a new mechanic is introduced alone first, then combined.
- Remote level packs later (download new levels without an app update).

PHASE 4 Monetization

Weeks 4-6

Goal: Earn money without hurting retention.

This genre (hybrid-casual puzzle) earns mostly from **ads**, plus a **Remove Ads** purchase. Rewarded ads that the player *chooses* to watch are the most valuable and least annoying.

Placement	Type	Rule
Continue after losing ("retry from checkpoint")	Rewarded	Always offered; biggest earner
Get a hint when out of hints	Rewarded	1 hint per ad
Skip a level	Rewarded	Only after 3 fails on the same level

Placement	Type	Rule
Double the coins after a win	Rewarded	Optional button on the win popup
Between levels	Interstitial	Not before level 4; at most every 2-3 levels and 60-90 s apart
Menus only (optional)	Banner	Never during gameplay; test if it hurts retention

In-app purchase	Suggested price	Notes
Remove Ads (keeps rewarded ads optional)	$2.99-$4.99	Most popular IAP in the genre
Hint packs (10 / 30 / 100)	$0.99-$4.99	Coins can also buy hints
Coin packs	$0.99-$9.99	Coins buy skins, hints, skips
Starter bundle (Remove Ads + hints + skin)	$4.99 one-time	Shown once after level 10
Skins: thief outfits, block themes	coins or $0.99-$1.99	Cosmetic only, never pay-to-win

- **Technology:** AdMob through a maintained Godot 4 AdMob plugin; Google Play Billing plugin for purchases. Add AppLovin MAX or AdMob mediation later to raise ad revenue.
- **Legal:** Google UMP consent form (GDPR/EU), privacy policy URL, Play "Data safety" form. Target age 13+ so the game is not under the stricter Families policy.
- **Economy:** coins from wins (more for 3 stars), daily reward and chests; spend on hints, skips and skins.

PHASE 5 Retention features — Weeks 5-8

Goal: Give players reasons to come back tomorrow.

- Daily reward calendar (7-day streak) and a chest every 5 levels.
- Star chests: collect stars to open rewards; achievements for skilful play.
- Local notifications ("Your daily reward is ready") - never more than once a day.
- Google Play Games sign-in, cloud save, leaderboard for total stars.
- Seasonal events (Halloween, winter) with themed levels and skins.

PHASE 6 Analytics, crash reporting & live config — Week 5-6

Goal: Make decisions from data, not guesses.

Tools: Firebase Analytics, Crashlytics and Remote Config (all free), using Godot plugins.

Event	Why we track it
level_start / level_win / level_fail (level, taps, time)	Find levels that are too hard or boring (drop-off funnel)
hint_used, skip_used, retry	See where players get stuck
ad_offer / ad_shown / ad_reward (placement)	Ad revenue and annoyance per placement
purchase (product, price)	Which offers work
tutorial_step, session_start	Onboarding quality, session length

Remote Config lets us change ad frequency, hint costs and even level order without an app update - and run A/B tests.

PHASE 7 Quality, performance & technical release prep — Weeks 6-7

Goal: No crashes, smooth on cheap phones, accepted by Google Play.

TODO	Device matrix: 1 low-end (2-3 GB RAM), 1 mid-range, 1 high-end Android; 60 FPS target, never under 30.
TODO	Graphics quality setting (Low/High) chosen automatically from FPS in the first seconds.

TODO	Crash-free sessions above 99.5% (Crashlytics). Fix every crash before scaling.
TODO	Build an **Android App Bundle (AAB)**, 64-bit, targeting the API level Google Play currently requires.
TODO	Create the **release upload key**; enroll in Play App Signing; back up the key.
TODO	App size check (aim under 100 MB), memory check, battery/heat check over 20 minutes of play.
TODO	Localization: English first; then Spanish, Portuguese, Hindi, Indonesian, Turkish, Arabic, Persian (store text + UI).

PHASE 8 Google Play launch — Weeks 7-10

Goal: Get on the store the right way, then soft-launch.

Important rule for new personal developer accounts: before you can publish to everyone, Google Play requires a **closed test with at least 12 testers opted in for 14 days in a row**. Start recruiting testers (friends, family, Discord/Reddit groups) early so this does not delay launch.

Step	Details
Play Console account	One-time $25 fee, identity verification (can take days)
Store listing	Title ("Save the Thief: Puzzle Rescue"), short + full description with keywords, icon, feature graphic, 8 screenshots, video
Content rating	IARC questionnaire (cartoon peril, no blood)
Policies	Privacy policy page, Data safety form, ads declaration, target audience 13+
Closed test	12+ testers, 14 days; collect feedback with a short form; fix top issues
Soft launch	Release in 2-4 smaller markets (e.g. Philippines, Indonesia, Brazil, Canada) and measure KPIs before going global
Global launch	Only when KPIs reach the targets below

PHASE 9 Marketing & user acquisition — From soft launch

Goal: Get players at a cost lower than what they earn us.

- **Short videos are the main channel:** post 3-5 clips a week on TikTok, YouTube Shorts and Instagram Reels. This genre goes viral with "almost fail" moments and "only 1% can solve this" hooks.
- Use the best organic clips as paid ads (TikTok Ads, Google App Campaigns, Unity/AppLovin). Start with a small daily budget per country and measure cost per install (CPI).
- Make a **playable ad** (one mini level in HTML5) once the game is proven - it is the highest-converting format for puzzles.
- App Store Optimization (ASO): test icons and screenshots with Play Console store listing experiments.
- Community: a Discord or Telegram group for testers and fans; ask happy players for reviews (in-app review API after a 3-star win).

PHASE 10 Live operations & growth — After launch

Goal: Keep the game growing for months.

- Update every 2 weeks: new levels, a new mechanic each month, fixes from analytics.
- Monthly events and limited skins; weekly challenge level with a leaderboard.
- Reply to every store review in the first months.
- **iOS version** when Android KPIs are good: needs a Mac (or cloud Mac), Apple Developer account ($99/year), App Store review.
- Later: new chapters, cross-promotion with a second game, more languages.

5. Timeline at a glance

Phase	W1	W2	W3	W4	W5	W6	W7	W8	W9	W10	W11	W12
1 Core polish & UI												
2 Art & models												
3 Levels to 60												
4 Monetization												
5 Retention features												
6 Analytics												
7 QA & release prep												
8 Closed test (14 days)												
8 Soft launch												
9 Marketing												
10 Global launch + live ops												

About 10-12 weeks to a global launch if work is steady. The closed test (14 days) and Play Console verification are fixed waiting times - start them as early as possible.

6. Numbers that decide success (KPIs)

KPI	Meaning	Good target for this genre
D1 retention	% of new players who return the next day	40% or more
D7 retention	% who return after a week	15% or more
D30 retention	% who return after a month	5% or more
Session length	Average minutes per session	8-12 minutes
Level 10 completion	% of new players who reach level 10	60% or more
Crash-free sessions	Sessions without a crash	99.5% or more
Store rating	Average review score	4.3 or more
CPI vs LTV	Cost to get one player vs money one player brings	LTV must be higher than CPI to scale paid ads

Targets are common industry benchmarks for casual puzzle games, not guarantees. Use them to decide whether to improve the game further or to start spending on ads.

7. Budget estimate

Item	Minimum (lean)	Recommended
Google Play Console	$25 one-time	$25 one-time
Thief model + animations	$0 (Mixamo)	$150-$400 custom character
Textures / UI art	$0-$20 (ChatGPT)	$200-$500 artist polish
Music / sound polish	$0 (own synth set)	$100-$300 composer theme
Test phones (low-end)	$0 (friends' phones)	$100-$150 one cheap Android
Soft-launch ad testing	$100-$300	$500-$1,500

Item	Minimum (lean)	Recommended
Apple Developer (later)	-	$99 / year
Total to global Android launch	**about $150-$350**	**about $1,100-$2,900**

8. Main risks and how we handle them

Risk	How we reduce it
Levels feel samey	New mechanic every ~10 levels; chapters with themes; analytics show boring levels
Physics unfair or random	Lingering-contact rule, automated win/fail tests per level, generous thresholds
Low-end phones lag	Quality presets, fewer bodies on Low, test on a cheap device before launch
Too many ads drive players away	Rewarded first, interstitial caps, Remote Config to tune without updates
Store rejection / policy issues	Privacy policy, Data safety, UMP consent, age 13+, follow ad policies
Closed-test requirement delays launch	Recruit 15-20 testers early; keep them engaged with updates
Losing the signing key	Play App Signing + two offline backups of the upload key

9. What we do next (this week)

NEXT	Reinstall the normal build on the phone; reproduce and fix the level-14 restart issue.
NEXT	Step 5: main menu, level map, pause, hints, settings (music / sound / vibration), tutorial hand.
NEXT	Fix lanterns for the Mobile renderer; add a Low/High graphics setting.
NEXT	Create the Git repository and make the first commit.
TODO	Generate the 14 textures with the ChatGPT prompts (step 7 file) and drop them into assets/textures/.
TODO	Download a Mixamo character + 5 animations for the thief and export as thief.glb.
TODO	Create the Google Play Console account now (verification takes time) and start listing testers.
TODO	Step 6: AdMob + consent + test ads; then analytics.

> **Rule of thumb:** polish the first 10 levels and the first 3 minutes of play more than anything else. That is where most players decide to stay or uninstall.